

hAdSpace: Leveraging Natural Human Emotions for Effective On-body Advertisements in Public Spaces

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Abstract

This satire video presents a fictitious system that uses projection-mapping to display advertisements on the faces of smiling people in public spaces. It posits that when a person sees advertisements on another person (e.g., a friend) in the moment of a positive emotional expression such as a smile, they naturally rechannel this positive emotion to the advertised product or service. This use of real expressions is presented as an improvement over conventional advertising methods that involve acted expressions, especially in printed or digital media. To support the claim of an effective, yet unobtrusive advertising method, the video describes a quantitative user evaluation, which closely follows the established evaluation paradigm in technical HCI research. The video concludes with several examples showcasing different ways of using the introduced advertising method. The critique expressed in this extended abstract and in the video is inherently subjective and does not represent the views of ACM or University of Stuttgart.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Interactive systems and tools**.

Keywords

Projection mapping, Advertisements, Emotions, Satire, User studies

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Note: It is assumed that the reader watched the video associated with this publication before reading this extended abstract.

1 The role of advertisements

Conceptually, the video combines physical on-body advertising methods, which involve voluntarily wearing advertisements [2] such as tattoos, with the subtle, almost invisible utilization of human identity and emotion found in digital advertisements (e.g., digital

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advertisements that are intertwined with human communication and engagement in social networks). Using our physical selves for advertisement, as shown in the video, can hence be seen as transforming digital advertising practices—in particular those that utilize human connection—into physical on-body advertisement.

Overall, in this satire video, advertising practices are not criticized directly. Rather, the video uses advertisement as a theme to establish an absurd interplay of human emotions, economical incentives, and technology.

2 Leveraging human emotions

Due to the type of video that this work mimics, viewers might naturally ask themselves "who created this system?" (if they take the video seriously or as suspension of disbelief). One goal is that the imagined creator of the system (a person or group who are not a direct part of the narrative, but whose motives are expressed through the visuals and the narration) is perceived as an entity who not only claims to understand emotions but also to experience them with the same intuition as the viewer. Concretely, the usage of "we" in the introduction together with a calm and thoughtful voice aims to serve as an attempt to build a sense of trust. As it becomes more apparent throughout the introduction that the pictures of smiling people are advertisements (which does not really fit to the thoughtful tone of the narration), the viewer might already doubt that the creator has good-natured incentives. The trust that the narration tries to build up in the beginning is eventually broken when introducing the system and arguing for its effective utilization of human connection. The arguments, in particular concerning the introduction's blurry critique of what can be considered "real" in terms of human connection, are becoming hypocritical, as it turns out that the creator does not aim to deepen but to exploit such connections. The narration also claims *simplicity*, not only in terms of utilizing human emotions but also with regards to how technology can be used to leverage them (ending with "And all it takes is a smile"), thereby ignoring technical and ethical concerns.

3 Technical HCI research and user studies

When a technical novelty is presented to the HCI community, its acceptance during peer-reviewing is often tied to whether or not the first practical attempt succeeds (or appears to succeed) in terms of efficiency or similar metrics. Claims regarding the success of a system or invention is typically supported by quantitative user evaluations and statistical testing¹. Even though, within technical

¹The scope of this critique is strictly within *technical* HCI (i.e., typical user evaluation requirements and practices in system papers). Hence, this scope *excludes* design research, designing and comparing interaction techniques, and so on.

HCI research, this practice has already been criticized in 2008 [1] and earlier, a user study with quantitative metrics is still considered a safe and pragmatic way to support claims regarding the success of a system and its usefulness.

The fictitious creator of the system exploits this pragmatism and tries to “prove” the non-absurdity of the system through scientific methods. The empirical method itself (and not whether it is appropriate to use it), together with tailored metrics and conditions that generate results that are in themselves significant and valid (within the scope of what was tested), are then used to declare the success of the system as a whole, even though its premise is absurd.

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References

- [1] Saul Greenberg and Bill Buxton. 2008. Usability evaluation considered harmful (some of the time). In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems* (Florence, Italy) (*CHI '08*). Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 111–120. <https://doi.org/10.1145/1357054.1357074>
- [2] Wikipedia. 2012. Forehead advertising. https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Forehead_advertising. Accessed: 11th of January 2025. Note: At the time of writing, this article lacks objectivity. However, it references various sources indicating that on-body advertisements have been experimented with in the early 2000s.